



IIT ROORKEE



NPTEL ONLINE
CERTIFICATION COURSE

PUBLIC SPEAKING

LECTURE 28: CONVERSATION

Prof. Binod Mishra

DEPARTMENT OF HUMANITIES AND SOCIAL SCIENCES



Persuasion versus Conversation

- ❑ Human communicative interaction involves an expression of attitudes, behaviours, needs, reasoning, feelings and viewpoints.

Persuasion is the art of convincing others to give favourable attention to our point of view. It intends to influence the beliefs, attitudes, values and acts of others.

PERSUASION

Conversation can be defined as oral and usually informal exchange of views, ideas and emotions. It is the most common form of dyadic communication.

CONVERSATION

Persuasion has become a pervasive part of our everyday life – finds application in advertising, marketing, sales, political campaigns.

PERSUASION

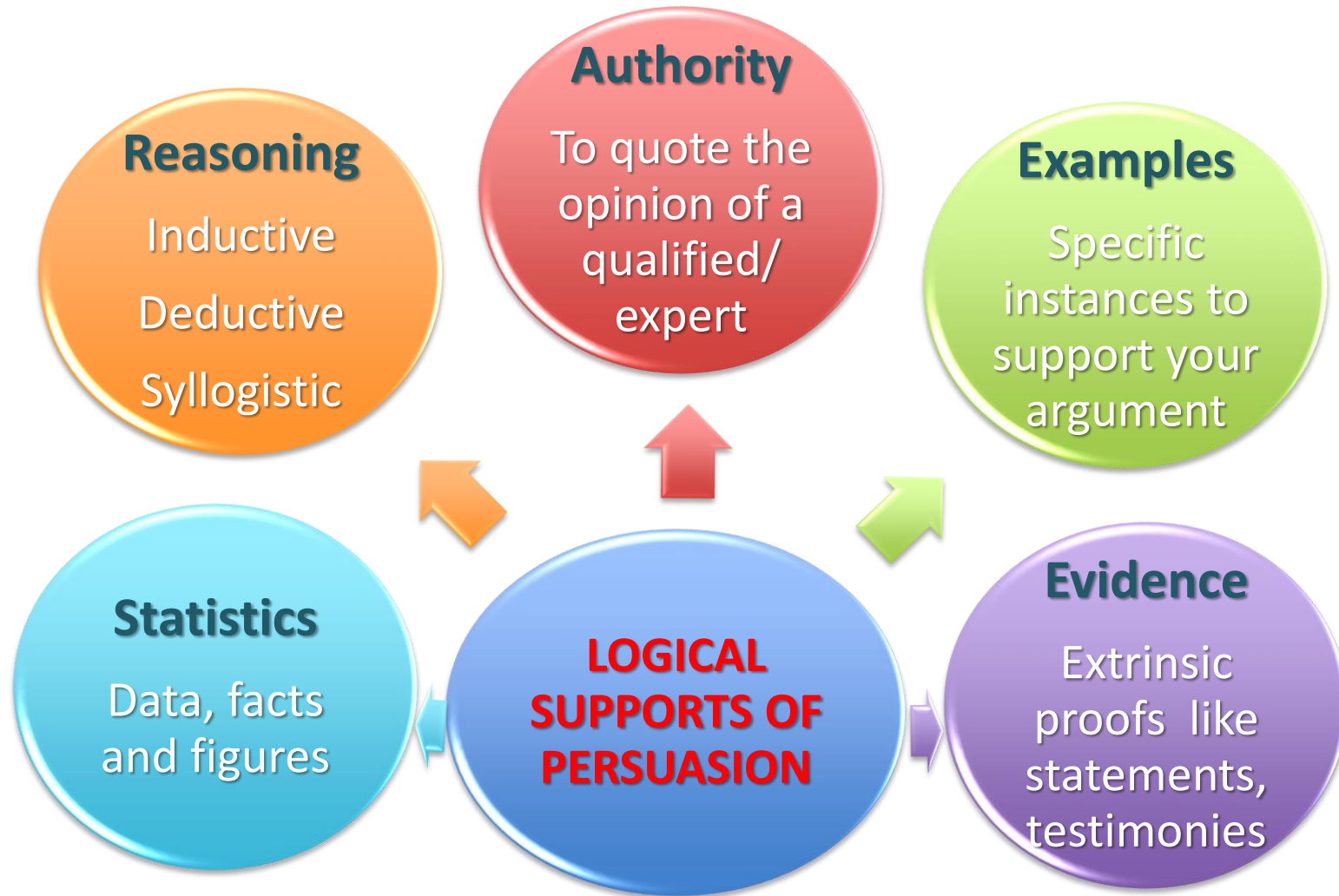


Strongly Disagree

Neutral

Strongly Agree

Logical Supports of Persuasion



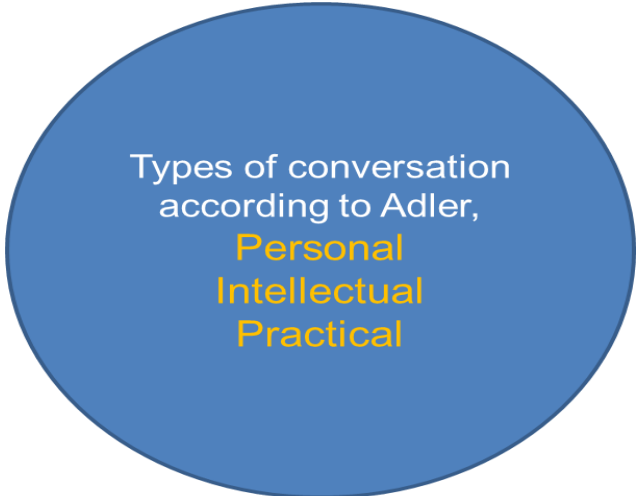
Inductive Reasoning
Arriving at a conclusion through observing specific cases

Deductive Reasoning
Applying a generally stated law to a particular case

Syllogism
Premise 1: All birds have wings.
Premise 2: All ostriches are birds.
Conclusion: Therefore, all ostriches have wings.

What is Conversation?

- ❑ “A talk, especially an informal one, between two or more people, in which news and ideas are exchanged.” (OED)
- ❑ “The most fruitful and natural exercise for our minds is, in my opinion, conversation. I find the practice of it pleasanter than anything else in life; and that is the reason why, if I were at this moment forced to choose, I would, I believe, rather consent to lose my sight than my hearing or speech” (Montaigne).
- ❑ “Preserve me from the thing I dread and hate,
A duel in the form of a debate.” (William Cowper)



Types of conversation
according to Adler,
Personal
Intellectual
Practical

Views of Creative Writers on Conversation

- ❑ “To my taste the most fruitful and most natural exercise of our minds is conversation. I find the practice of it the most delightful activity in our lives” (Montaigne).
- ❑ “...we intend by it that reciprocal interchange of ideas by which truth is examined, things are, in a manner, turned round and sifted, and all our knowledge communicated to each other” (Henry Fielding, ‘An Essay On Conversation’).
- ❑ “Some, without any ceremony, will run over the history of their lives; will relate the annals of their diseases, with the several symptoms and circumstances of them; will enumerate the hardships and injustice they have suffered in court, in parliament, in love, or in law” (Jonathan Swift).

Contd...

- ❑ “He lends his ear to an observation as if you had brought him a piece of news, and enters into it with as much avidity and earnestness as if it interested himself personally” (William Hazlitt).
- ❑ “Of all things, banish the egotism out of your conversation, and never think of entertaining people with your own personal concerns or private affairs; though they are interesting to you they are tedious and impertinent to everybody else” (Lord Chesterfield).

Henry Fielding's Views

- ❑ “First, that every person who indulges his ill-nature or vanity at the expense of others, and in introducing uneasiness, vexation, and confusion into society, however exalted or high-titled he may be, is thoroughly ill-bred.”
- ❑ “Secondly, that whoever, from the goodness of his disposition or understanding, endeavors to his utmost, to cultivate the good-humour and happiness of others, and to contribute to the ease and comfort of all his acquaintance, however low in rank fortune may have placed him, or however clumsy he may be in his figure or demeanor, hath, in the truest sense of the word, a claim to good-breeding.”

Purposes of Persuasive Speaking

Strengthening Commitment

To strengthen the commitment of the listeners to a belief they already possess

- Raise consciousness about the cause.
- Lead from educating to commitment.
- Convey a sense of urgency.

Weakening Commitment

To weaken the belief of an audience committed strongly in opposition to the views of the speaker

- Find a critical distinction.
- Develop a contrary claim.
- Present a sound and strong refutation.

Conversion

To alter listener's belief - abandoning one idea and replacing it with another

- Identify a pattern of anomalies in the belief.
- Aim for a slow conversion- in gradual modest steps.

Inducing a Specific Action

To move the audience from a strong belief to a specific action

- State the desired action specifically and precisely.
- Make the task easy to perform – through preparations beforehand.

Elaboration Likelihood Model

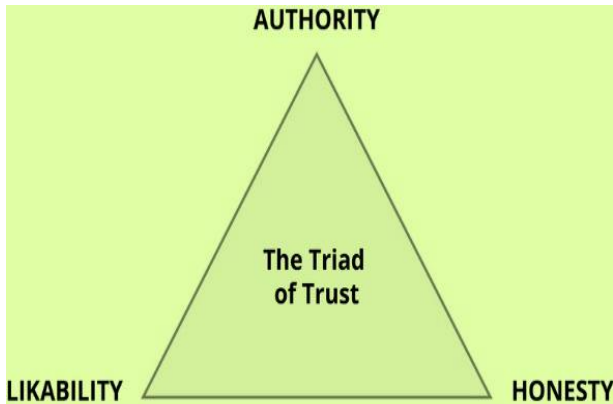


- ❖ **Elaboration** refers to audience's tendency to think critically about the message of the speech.
- ❖ When audience's **elaboration tendency is high**, the persuasive power depends upon the **standards of arguments** and **logic of reasoning**.
- ❖ In case of audience's **low elaboration**, the persuasive power depends upon the **positive ethos** and **likeability** of the speaker.

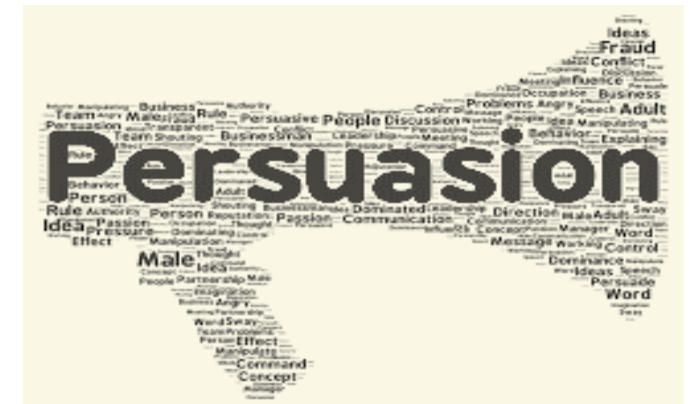
A Fair Approach to Persuasion

AUDIENCE -SENSITIVITY
Motivate audience to willingly
consider the other side.

QUALIFIED LANGUAGE
Avoid overstatement & over-generalization.



***“The pendulum of the mind
alternates between sense
and nonsense, not between
right and wrong.”
– Carl Jung***



OBJECTIVITY

Fair, Honest, Evidence-based

COMMON GROUNDS
Do not target the audience
as opposition; look for
commonality.

Interpersonal Conversation: Influencing Factors

A healthy and engaging conversation stems from underlying **interpersonal attraction**. This bond is shaped and strengthened by **five major factors**:

1. **Nearness** – Physical proximity between two individuals strengthens the attraction between them, provided other factors like their personal beliefs and attitudes are not in gross conflict with each other.
2. **Similarity** – Similar interests, attitudes and momentary feelings create a stronger adhesive bond between strangers.
3. **Social Adaptability** – People with healthy self-concepts and a poised sociable attitude are more attractive than either extremities of the attitude like excessive superiority, egoism, timidity or withdrawal.
4. **Social Status** – We tend to get attracted towards people who provide us with recognition and praise.
5. **Physical Attributes** – First impression cast by the physical characteristics of an individual – like appearance, clothing, calorie count, energy level, body language – play a crucial role in interpersonal attraction.

Requisites of Conversation

- ☐ Common ground
- ☐ Interest
- ☐ Attention
- ☐ Time and space
- ☐ Curiosity
- ☐ Observation
- ☐ Eye contact
- ☐ Feedback

Psychological Climate of Healthy Conversation

A **healthy conversation** can be defined as an interpersonal interaction facilitated in a **cohesive environment**, in which the participants achieve a mental state of **psychological safety** and **freedom of thought and expression**.

Carl R. Rogers, in his book '*On Becoming a Person*' (1961), counsels on the psychological conditions that aid a healthy conversation –

- ❑ The **degree of warmth and cordiality** they feel with each other
- ❑ The **willingness to be frank and honest** in their expression of ideas and emotions
- ❑ The **degree of congruence** of their experiences and awareness – the greater the congruence, the higher is the mutual satisfaction in relationships.

"In my relationship with persons, I have found that it does not help, in the long run, to act as though I were something that I am not.

I find that I am more effective when I can listen acceptably to myself, and can be myself."

- Carl R. Rogers
On Becoming a Person (1961)

Conversational Variety

NARRATIVE

A sequence of events recounted either in chronological or otherwise order

E.g. – Recounting an anecdote

DESCRIPTION

Conversation describing what/how things look, feel, taste, sound or smell like

E.g. – Describing experience of a trip

CONVERSATION

EXPOSITION

Description of processes and patterns, explanations and analysis

E.g. – Explaining how to cook a dish

ARGUMENT

Expression of one's point of view to persuade or influence others based on evidence or reasoning

E.g. – Arguing for/against the system of biometric attendance for students

General Purposes of Conversation

Raymond S. Ross, in his book ***Speech Communication: Fundamentals and Practice***, enlists five primary purposes or agendas of conversation:



Social Gatherings – For fun, joy, companionship

To **ventilate** our pent-up feelings to a sympathetic listener

Therapeutic – To seek help, counsel, support or information

Bargaining – To negotiate differences in a cooperative manner

Evaluation – To ask for feedback or to evaluate

The Art of Conversation

Sir Richard Steele, in his essay ***The Art of Conversation***, instructs:

- ❑ The ideal conversation should not be a laboured one, rather should be readily and clearly apprehended.
- ❑ In a conversation, the chief end should be neither to affect silence nor to flaunt eloquence.
- ❑ Pedantry is the outcome of much reading but little comprehending.
- ❑ Conversation ought to be neither an attempt to polite sycophancy nor of a determined disputation.

“The great enemies, therefore, to good company, and those who transgress most against the laws of equality which is the life of it, are, the clown, the wit, and the pedant.”

- Sir Richard Steele
(Spectator, No.100)

Contd...

- ☐ In case of a difference of opinions, one should introduce one's point of view by some agreeable circumlocution.
- ☐ One should exhibit patience and curiosity to understand the speaker.
- ☐ To possess and express good sense and goodwill are the vital qualities for companions in an ideal conversation.
- ☐ The ideal conversationalist ought to practise deference in disagreements.

Precautions during Conversation

- ❖ Arguments
- ❖ Slander
- ❖ Sarcasms
- ❖ Blasphemy
- ❖ Indecency
- ❖ Remembrance of some untoward past
- ❖ Neither a dirge at a wedding nor an epithalamium at a funeral

Etiquettes of Conversation

DO's

- ✓ Begin the talk with a topic of common interest
- ✓ Occasionally address the person by name
- ✓ Be mindful of your language and demeanor
- ✓ Cultivate a cheerful and friendly tone
- ✓ Practise attentive listening

DON'Ts

- × Abstain from being dogmatic or argumentative
- × Avoid use of superfluous vocabulary
- × Do away with exaggeration and affectation
- × Do not sound impatient or flustered
- × Do not use slang

let's talk

“Everything we hear is an opinion, not a fact.
Everything we see is a perspective, not the
truth.”

~ Marcus Aurelius

Thank You!

WORKS CONSULTED

- Fielding, Henry. “ An Essay On Conversation”. <http://www.public-library.uk/ebooks/33/15.pdf>
- Mohan Krishna, Meera Banerjee. *Developing Communication Skills*. New Delhi: Trinity Press, 2017. Print.
- Ross, Raymond S. *Speech Communication Fundamentals and Practice*. New Jersey: Prentice-Hall, Inc., 1977. Print.
- Sharma, Sangeeta and Binod Mishra. *Communication Skills for Engineers and Scientists*. New Delhi: PHI Learning. 2009, 6th Reprint 2015.
- Stephen, Lucas E. *The Art of Public Speaking*. New York: McGraw Hill, 2009.
- Zarefsky, David. *Public Speaking: Strategies for Success*. Boston: Allyn & Bacon, 2011. Print.
- <https://www.thecollector.com/art-of-conversation-from-cicero-to-habermas/>
- <http://fullreads.com/essay/hints-towards-an-essay-on-conversation/>